Temple Beth Torah Times

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Remembrance Pops Up Throughout TBT

By Allison Rothstein

Yom HaShoah v'HaG'vurah, Holocaust and Heroism Day, is usually commemorated with a Maariv service, songs and special prayers – but this year, over 300 congregants, members of the Long Island community and Holocaust survivors joined together to celebrate in a unique fashion: a Pop-Up Holocaust Museum.

The term "pop-up" was originally coined to describe retail initiatives that quickly popped-up in temporary locations, created some excitement and frenzy and then, just as rapidly, disappeared. A Pop-Up Holocaust Museum is a one-day exhibit of Holocaust photos, artifacts, narratives, speakers and films that are all arranged for interactive experiences and displays.

On Sunday, April 7, Holocaust survivors and members of Temple Beth Torah were able to relive their families' experiences and hardships and share unique stories, artifacts and documents, some of which – artwork, a yellow armband with a Star of David, a 150-year-old oil-burning menorah and Kiddush cup, and a tallis – had never been seen before.

Amongst those sharing their families' histories was Temple Beth Torah president, **Renee Kornet**.

"While my children were fortunate to have my mother tell them about her experiences, it's important for other children to learn about the Holocaust through these first person narratives," Renee said. "There's always another amazing story. I hope the children learned that bad things happened to kids just like them…[and] they went on to have families who are members of our temple.

Rabbi Katz felt that visitors should not just feel compassion for the survivors, but they should also remember the lives of those who walked through challenging times with courage, valor and the very strong sense of what it means to be a Jew.

"Adults know the story and the history; but that is planted somewhere in the back of their minds. Ritual helps those seeds to grow, and to flower and bear fruit. Our program helped remind them, and helped turn intellectual facts into emotional reality," Rabbi Katz said. "For kids, who may not know the story, we were planting the seeds of Jewish history and experience."

In addition to the museum, multiple films were shown. The first, titled Daniel's Story, came from the United States Holocaust Memorial Museum. Geared towards younger visitors, this film documented a young boy's journey through Germany from the time

(Continued on page 4)

Press from the President
A Walk Through Our Temple

By Renee Kornet

If you take a look at a temple's calendar, it tells you a lot about that temple. Some calendars routinely tell you about Shabbat candle lighting times, holiday observances, and Fast days. Let's walk through our Temple Beth Torah calendar and see what makes us unique.

Clearly, the months of September and October are filled with holidays from Rosh Hashanah through Simhat Torah, no matter where you are. However, if you take a look at the TBT calendar, you will already see some subtle differences. You might, for example, note that on a Sunday morning between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, there is Tashlich. So how does a temple that's miles from water have a Tashlich service where we cast our sins (symbolically speaking) into the water? It's because we have an innovative Rabbi who puts together a unique experience at the beach in Oyster Bay.

In October, you will note that on a Friday night, there is the first Family service. What makes that night different from other Friday nights is that we have an amazing Cantor who works with a group of children ranging in age from our newest Hebrew school students to our most senior High school students. Impossible you might say? Skillfully, our Cantor makes this work.

A look at November and you will see a Grandparent Shabbat on the calendar. Grandparents from near and far come for this special Saturday morning service. The "kvell" meter is running that morning and can be felt from here to Boca. Then, in December, our families partake not only in the "Classic Hanukkah Breakfast", brought to us by Men's Club, but this year we also had an amazing Lego Menorah project. Photos of this menorah only partly tell the story of what was a most memorable morning for children and parents alike.

Purim fell early this year and people predicted low attendance because it fell on a weekend during the February vacation. Not so at Temple Beth Torah! Our Megillah readers came out in full force out of respect for the Cantor. The Rabbi was in his prime with his Purim antics and Purim baskets filled our halls. The Carnival that followed the next morning was complete with fun and games.

Yom HaShoah is usually observed with a memorial service (after Passover) in April, but this year we had a Holocaust Pop-Up Museum, put together by congregants who were second generation (and in some cases, first generation) survivors. Over 300 people turned out to see the artifacts that were on display and to hear the narratives of temple families whose parents survived and went on to lead successful lives in this country. This was an event that will long be remembered by a new generation of children at Temple Beth Torah.

Sisterhood Game Night has become a new tradition at Temple Beth Torah. Women turned out this year en masse for a night of bridge, canasta, boutique shopping, and fun in April.

May is usually when Sisterhood Shabbat is scheduled. Once again, Cantor Fliegelman performs his magic and trains the women in our synagogue to lead us all in services.

June is now host to another special event. The Long Island Kosher Barbeque will take place on June 9th. This year promises to be even better than last as thousands of participants are expected. Is there another temple in our area that has an award-winning recipe for "pulled brisket sandwiches?"

So, the next time you are out to dinner with friends and they tell you what's happening at their temple (for me this actually does happen quite often…), just walk them through our calendar. Temple Beth Torah is a special place and we all know that…it is just amazing to see what happens here over the course of a year.

Temple Beth Torah Services

Memorial Plaques - Barbara Mazzei, 334-7979

Dedication of Prayer Book -Barbara Mazzei, 334-7979

Tree of Life -Barbara Mazzei, 334-7979

Catering
Fairway - Risa Katz, 780-0640

Sponsoring Kiddush / Oneg -Barbara Mazzei, 334-7979

For Kippot - Tammy Strobel, 933-6802
tammystrobel95@gmail.com

Torah Cards
Francine Dorman, 681-6449
Linda Pochtar, 933-0963

Trees for Israel (Jewish National Fund)
Barbara Mazzei, 334-7979
Or JNF 212-678-6800

Off the Bimah

By Rabbi Michael Katz

Being a Jew vs. Being Jewish

If your mother was a Jew, (or if you converted to Judaism) then you are a Jew. It's as simple as that. Nothing else is required.

Being Jewish is a whole different story. That requires a lot of effort.

What difference does it make? The survival of the Jewish people is not based on how many Jews there are in the world, but on how Jewish those Jews are. And, being Jewish can enrich your life in ways that being a Jew just can't.

Here's a little scorecard, just to figure out how Jewish you are. Give yourself 1 point for each question you can answer "YES".

(Every Day)
1 I have a Mezuzah on every door of my house (except bathrooms and closets)
2 I pray (almost) every day saying Hebrew prayers
3 I avoid non-kosher food (pork, shellfish)
4 I buy only kosher meat
5 I have a kosher kitchen (two sets of dishes, etc.)

(Shabbat)
6 I light Shabbat candles every Friday
7 I have a Shabbat dinner each week
8 I attend a Shabbat service almost every week
9 I make every effort not to work on Shabbat

(Holidays)
10 I attend Rosh HaShana services and hear the Shofar
11 I attend Yom Kippur services and fast
12 I attend Sukkot services and shake the Lulav and Etrog
13 I build a Sukkah
14 I attend Shmini Atzeret/Simhat Torah services
15 I light Hanukkah candles with the blessings
16 I attend Purim services and hear the Megilah
17 I participate in Passover Seders
18 I attend Passover services
19 I don't eat Hametz (bread and leavened products) during Passover
20 I attend Shavuot services

(Life Cycle events)
21 My son had a Bris, my daughter a Baby naming
22 My child attended religious school
23 I am involved in Jewish learning
24 My child had a Bar/Bat Mitzvah service
25 I had a Jewish wedding (Huppah, Ketubah)
26 I would have a Jewish funeral/burial for my parents
27 I would sit Shiva for my parents
28 I would recite Kaddish for my parents
29 I would observe Yahrzeit/say Yizkor for my parents
30 I belong to a Synagogue

(Israel)
31 I have visited Israel
32 I support Israel financially and politically

(Holocaust)
33 I read about and commemorate the Holocaust

(Ethics)
34 I contribute to Tzedakah
35 I support Jewish causes
36 I try to act in an ethical way because I am Jewish

I can't tell you:
"Less than 10 and you're a bad Jew" or "Over 25 and you're a Tzaddik."

More than a grade, this checklist is a reminder of what is involved in "being Jewish." And hopefully, it can serve as a plan for action in the coming year, of the things we'd like to work on- and achieve.

"Questions and Reflections"

From: TALKING TO GOD
by Rabbi Naomi Levy

In Honor of Mother's and Father's Day…

A Blessing For Children to Say to Their Parents

You gave me my life…

You give me your wisdom, your guidance, your concern, your love...

You are my mentor, my protector, my moral compass, my comfort. There are no words to express my gratitude for all the blessings you have given me…

Still, I tell you, thank you.

May God bless you as you have blessed me,
with life, with health, with joy, and with love…

Amen.

Remembrance Pops Up Throughout TBT

(Continued from page 1)

he was a young boy of 6 years old to his tumultuous teenage years.

"Have you ever been punished for something you didn't do?" Daniel said. "I felt like the Nazis had stolen our lives."

Daniel's father also shared how it felt to be a Jew during these troubling times.

"No one can steal your mind or your heart. What we feel makes us human," he said. "Listen and remember."

The second film, a catalog of survival reflections, was a product of the Museum of Tolerance in Glen Cove, NY. These "stories of courage" shared both survivor and liberator accounts of the horrors of the Holocaust.

One of the featured liberators stated that the Nazis' actions "fanned the flames of widespread anti-Semitism."

"The only crime [the Jews] committed was being Jewish, and they had to withstand all of these horrors," he said. "What had to be the most horrible sight of all was those who were still barely alive."

While the films emphasized the ability to garner appreciation for the differences between people, the overall theme of the program was survival.

"Often we concentrate on those we lost and we see pictures of emaciated bodies," Rabbi Katz said. "What we tried to do was show that the Jewish people survived – here are their children!"

Renee hoped that visitors were able to see that out of the horror and despair, there were children and adults who managed to survive and start anew.

"We see in our Temple the amazing way that the survival of even one child may have led to a marriage, children, grandchildren and soon another generation," she said. "We also see the strength and ability of people to go on with life and the joy that followed."

At the conclusion of the exhibits, speaker and Holocaust survivor Janet Ettleman shared her story of endurance and escape from southern Germany. The program concluded with a memorial service led by **Rabbi Katz** and **Cantor Fliegelman**.

According to Rabbi Katz, the Israeli government established Yom HaShoah v'HaG'vurah to be observed on the 27th of Nisan. This date was chosen because of its proximity to the Warsaw Ghetto Uprising in April 1943. The Israelis wanted to put the emphasis on Resistance, not just slaughter.

Cantor Fliegelman fittingly sang Es Brent, a poem written in 1938 by Mordechai Gebirtig after a pogrom in Poland. It says: "Brothers! Our town is burning! And you just stand by, with your arms folded, doing nothing!"

Hilari Cohen, who was responsible for bringing the concept of the Pop-Up Museum to TBT and who served as committee chair, was thrilled with the response of the community and the temple congregants.

"We never expected the huge turnout but were delighted nonetheless," she said. "The idea came about when I attended a Yom HaShoah lecture the previous year at Great Neck Synagogue and sat next to another child of a survivor. She told me that her temple – Young Israel of Great Neck – was holding a similar pop-up museum and it made me think about bringing the concept to TBT."

Hilari attributed this success to her committee for their commitment and dedication. The committee – which included **Renee Kornet, Jerry Cohen, Roger Loeb, Penny and Harry Rapaport, Libby Friedman, Fran Greene, Fred Gross, Lisa Merkrebs, Wendy Marx, Marty Elberg, Jon Tolpin, Jack Abramowicz and Hilari Cohen** – shared their own personal stories of survival and strength and worked to ensure that every congregant and guest walked away with a strong sense of what it means to be a Jew.

"We as a Jewish people have survived, Rabbi Katz said. "Here we are."

A Celebration of Jewish Resiliency

By Orna Sheena

Throughout history, we, the Jewish people, have experienced many ups and downs and trials that tested the resiliency that sustained us. We have fought for our survival. We have safeguarded our heritage and the wisdom of the Torah, which has been passed down from generation to generation. We have succeeded when we pulled together as a united community.

At TBT, we teach our students about the challenging times in Jewish history and focus on our ability to turn tragedy into triumph. During the period of Passover, we learned about the transition from slavery to freedom. And in recent weeks, we demonstrated the transition from sadness -- remembering the Holocaust, as well as the fallen heroes of Israel -- into a joyous celebration of Yom Ha'Atzmaut, Israel's Independence Day.

We commemorated Yom HaShoah in a solemn candle-lighting ceremony with readings about the Holocaust. And on Yom HaZikaron, Israel's Remembrance Day, we remembered the thousands who lost their lives defending Israel, as well as those who were victims of terror.

To mark Israel's 65th Independence Day, students discussed Israel's miracle of survival, its growth, and achievements. They watched videos which showcased Israel's innovation and entrepreneurship in so many spheres -- culture, technology, business, medicine, and far more. In spite of the overwhelming challenges such as wars and terror attacks that this tiny country experiences on a daily basis, its people demonstrate remarkable resilience and courage.

To make Israel's birthday celebration extra sweet, our students decorated sponge cakes with white frosting and blue sprinkles to represent the flag of Israel, and of course they enjoyed eating them. Also, in keeping with Israel's security challenges, our students were put through military exercises by our favorite Israeli IDF soldier Amit -- an all-time favorite activity.

We continue to learn about Israel and important Biblical characters through an interactive WebQuest, an inquiry-oriented project in which the students gather information about their personalities from online resources. In Special Activities, Mrs. Levine has them creating and dressing their Biblical characters. Once the project is complete, the children will present their findings to the other classes and trace their character's journey in Israel and neighboring countries using the large Israel floor map.

During the upcoming month, as we celebrate Lag B'Omer, Yom Yerushalayim (Jerusalem Day), and Shavuot, we are again reminded that our beliefs, traditions, and heritage give us the determination and courage to secure our future.

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www.templebethtorahli.org
tbtyouth@aol.com

Affiliated with the United Synagogue
of Conservative Judaism

Rabbi..... Michael Katz
Cantor..... Kalman J. Fliegelman
President..... Renee Kornet
Educational Director..... Orna Sheena

Temple Beth Torah Times
Editor Emeritus..... Raymond M. Schleicher
Editors..... Jane Berliner
..... Meryll Feinstein
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Luck Be a Lady Tonight

By Ruth Damon and Lisa Silverman

On Tuesday, April 23rd, 2013, Sisterhood held its 3rd annual Ladies Game Night in TBT's Social hall. We had a wonderful turnout with over 40 women in attendance. Many women enjoyed the evening playing "Mah Jongg," while others brought their favorite game of "Scattegories" or "Scrabble." There was a new spin this year with three learning tables for canasta. The women who learned canasta will even be continuing on for a few more weeks of learning sessions. We had two wonderful shopping vendors who sold beautiful jewelry and pocket books. In addition, we had many great raffles from local vendors and so many winners that evening! Whether you were the lucky winner of your game or the winner of a raffle, we think that everyone would agree – the evening was filled with fun. Desserts and laughs were just the icing on the cake!

We would like to thank all of the ladies who attended the evening. It was a huge success and we look forward to next year's event being even better!!

RIVKIN RADLER LLP
ATTORNEYS AT LAW
Howard M. Merkrebs
Partner
howard.merkrebs@rivkin.com
926 RXR Plaza, Uniondale, NY 11556-0926
D 516.357.3051 T 516.357.3000 F 516.357.3333
555 Madison Avenue, New York, NY 10022-3338
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FAX: 516-681-3612
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Ethics, Morality and Restitution

The Holocaust's Impact on the Art World: "The Portrait of Wally"

By Jane Berliner

On Sunday evening, March 10th, Fred Gross, a congregant and docent for the Holocaust Memorial and Tolerance Center of Nassau County, showcased a documentary film called "Portrait of Wally," produced by Andrew Shea. The film, which was shown at the Tribeca Film Festival last year, traces the history of this 1912 oil painting of Valerie "Wally" Neuzil, a model who posed for Austrian painter Egon Schiele.

The painting was originally owned by Lea Bondi, who was fleeing the German annexation of Austria and had, under duress, given up the painting to art dealer, Fredrich Welz in 1939. At the end of the War, the U.S. Army seized Welz, a known Nazi, and recovered the paintings that he had accumulated during the War. The "Portrait of Wally" was turned over to the Austrian National Gallery and then sold to Rudolf Leopold in 1954 to become part of the collection of the Leopold Museum in Austria. In 1997, the portrait was loaned to the Museum of Modern Art (MoMa) as part of an exhibit of Egon Schiele's work. When the New York Times published the history of the painting, the heirs of Lea Bondi contacted then District Attorney, Robert Morgenthau, who issued a subpoena forbidding the painting's return to Austria. The Museum of Modern Art, on the other hand, felt if it was seized by the U.S. government and not returned to Austria, it would put into question the museum's ability, in the future, to borrow art freely from abroad. Bondi's heirs claimed that the painting was Nazi plunder and should have been returned to them after the War. The litigation lasted 13 years and in July, 2010, the Leopold Museum agreed to pay $19 million to Bondi's heirs under an agreement that addressed all outstanding claims on the painting.

Fred raised several questions highlighting the essence of this documentary film such as: Was the case about money and greed or about righting a wrong? Did Rudolf Leopold know that the "Portrait of Wally" was stolen when he acquired it? Do we too easily focus on the Holocaust as a conflict of victim and perpetrator and as a result diminish or lose focus on the role of bystanders and collaborators?

The "Wally" case brought the story of looted Nazi art into the open, eventually forcing museums in Europe and the U.S. to search their own collections for suspected holdings. Many museums ended up returning their art to Jewish families who had abandoned hope until "Wally" showed that institutions could be held accountable for holding property stolen during the Holocaust. The resolution of this litigation highlighted the reluctance of major institutions in Europe and New York to send the "last prisoners of war" back to their families.

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The Next Step...

Temple Beth Torah is pleased to showcase our newest bar/bat mitzvah students at their proudest moments. We feature them in order to gain their insights as to the meaning of this momentous and significant Jewish event in their lives.

Each student was asked the following questions:
- What activities are you involved in and what accomplishments are you proudest of?
- What does becoming a bar/bat mitzvah mean to you?
- What mitzvah project did you undertake for your bar/bat mitzvah?

SHAINA HORN (March 2nd)

I am proud to be on the Middle school track and soccer teams. My major accomplishment was making the Principal's Honor Roll in school for grade achievements in my honor's classes.

I am very proud of myself. I moved here from Florida 1 ½ years ago, and went from belonging to a Reform temple to a Conservative one. I knew very little Hebrew before I came here and I had the longest Haftorah of the year and mastered it!

As a mitzvah project, I did a toy drive for FEGS, a part of UJA. My original goal was to collect 30 toys, but through the generosity of our temple members, I ended up collecting 131 toys. I also did a food drive for FEGS and ended up donating 72 food items to their food bank. These baskets were displayed on the bimah at my bat mitzvah.

HALLE FISHMAN (April 13th)

I am on the Middle school tennis, basketball, and lacrosse teams. I also play travel basketball, and travel soccer.

Becoming a bat mitzvah means that now I am considered an adult in the Jewish community and can be counted as an adult in minyans and in all areas of Jewish life.

I usually participate in leading a part of our services on Yom Kippur.

ROSS MESNICK (April 20th)

I'm proud that I qualified for the temple Honor Roll for attending the Rabbi's class a maximum number of times. I'm also proud of being a Junior at the Jericho Fire Department, which is a form of community service and means that I help the department at their events. I'm in the Student Leadership program at the Middle school, which helps fundraisers and outside organizations and charities.

Becoming a bar mitzvah means I can participate in services as a Torah reader, that I count in a minyan, and that now I have added responsibilities as a Jew.

For my bar mitzvah, I collected monetary donations as well as soda tab donations and brought them to the Ronald McDonald House of Long Island.

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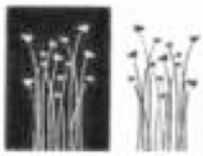

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Rays of this + that!

Mazel Tov to **Andrea and Allen Algaze** on the engagement of their son **Josh** to **Samantha Cooper**… to **Fern and Jim Pasternack** on the engagement of their daughter **Trisha** to **Marc Berliner**…and to **Judi and Howard Teig** on the marriage of their son **Edward** to **Michelle Wexler**.

Get Well… Carol Fliegelman, Len Austin, Charles Seidman, Craig Lewis.

Our Condolences to **Wendy Gray** on the passing of her mother, **Dorothy Rosel**…to **Marilyn Buchman** on the passing of her husband, beloved member, **Sidney Buchman**…to **Meryl Fischer** on the passing of her mother, **Harriet Ross**…to the **Aaron Family** on the passing our beloved member, **Marcia Aaron**… to **Robin Schaffler** on the passing of her mother, **Beatrice Miller**…to **Larry Shiffrin** on the passing of his father, **Edward**…to **Glenn Unger** on the passing of his mother, **Dorothy**…to **Seymour Roth** on the passing of his brother, **Sidney**.

Mazel Tov to **Marjorie and Marty Elbaum** on the birth of their granddaughter, **Anna Sophia**, born to their children, **Adam and Sarina**.

Mazel Tov to **Nancy and Perry Horn** on the bat mitzvah of their daughter, **Shaina**…to **Marcy and Ken Fishman** on the bat mitzvah of their daughter, **Halle**…to **Karen and Andrew Mesnick** on the bar mitzvah of their son, **Ross**.

Some Time Ago

By Marilyn Reich

Some time ago, a comedian performed at my condo. She had been one of the past writers for Saturday Night Live. She was a funny lady, but I modestly must report, I got a laugh from the audience equal to hers. She asked," What makes building two so special?" (That's the one I live in) I yelled out," We get up." Although, funny at that time, I now think how miraculous that phrase is.

We get up to enjoy the world around us, to take for granted the beauty of the world. If you look up the word miracle, it refers you to wonders. God's wonders are patterns of nature. Leaves turn color and wilt, only to be reborn with new brilliance. The sun rises each morning in the east only to set at dusk in the west. The clouds darken to release the rain and then like a miracle the sky lightens and the clouds float away. Nature is a miracle.

God manages every aspect of creation. He created nature - a world of cause and effect. Nature could be a way for God to hide his identity. He allows man to find his hand. At times he breaks through nature. He splits the sea. He cures a child from disease. He guides a nation to survive war. Through these supernatural occurrences we can see nature as a creation of God. By waking up each morning we experience the most incredible miracle - Life. We have all had our miracles. I wonder, are there really miracles, or are there predetermined plans for life. I believe that God has predetermined life, but with prayer I can ask him to break through and grant me a miracle.

Look around and relish God's miracles.

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What is a Jew?

By Stanley Greenberg

I recently re-read the "Merchant of Venice" by William Shakespeare and I came away with a different view of the character Shylock. He has historically been characterized as a villain, and a Jew with no heart and no human feelings. I disagree.

The "Merchant of Venice", Antonio, has borrowed 3,000 golden ducats from Shylock for three months. He believes that one of his four merchant vessels presently on the high seas will return to cover his debt to the villainous Jew. Shylock has always been degraded by Antonio's blatant anti-Semitism, even spat upon in public. If Antonio cannot repay the loan, Shylock has asked for a "pound of flesh" as his fee.

Eventually Shylock's daughter, Jessica, steals the rest of Shylock's money and runs off with her Christian boyfriend, Lorenzo. Shylock becomes embittered against society and Antonio in particular. Antonio states he would call Shylock a dog again and spit on him again in the Rialto. Shylock says, "Hath a dog money. I will loan him the money and the pound of man's flesh is useless, not like the flesh of sheep, beef or goats."

With his daughter and money stolen and gone, Shylock becomes vengeful. At the court, before a Venetian Duke, Shylock demands his "pound of flesh." He is asked to be merciful by Portia, Antonio's lawyer.

In a famous speech, Shylock says, "I am a Jew. Hath not a Jew hands, organs, dimensions, senses, affections, passions? Fed with the same food, hurt with the same weapons, subject to the same diseases, healed by the same means, warmed and cooled by the same winter and summer as a Christian? If you prick us do we not bleed? If you tickle us, do we not laugh? And if you wrong us, shall we not revenge?"

Shylock has been cast in a negative light in this play – he is a Jew and a usurer. When the play's characters ask Shylock for mercy, he offers none. But I look at it from the other side. In this play, Shylock is faced with losing everything and is stuck in a lose/lose situation. He conspired to kill a Christian, is forced to convert to Christianity, and has a daughter who stole his money and ran off with a Christian. In rereading Shylock's story, I can feel his helplessness and frustration as an outcast. He is caged and is given no mercy. I have now attained a new and better view of Shylock's position as a Jew and stranger during that period of time.

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Poetry and Jewish Catastrophe (Not as Bleak as the Title Sounds)

By Jane Berliner

This year was the 17th anniversary of our Sam Abraham's Memorial Lecture Series, "Scholars in Residence." This program has traditionally been sponsored by **Irene Abrahams** and her family, **Kenny, Danny, Jonathan** and her granddaughter **Ellen**, honoring her late husband's (one of the founders of our temple) belief in the importance of Judaic scholarship. He felt, "Judaism is a diamond with many facets. There are many sides to Judaism: culture, learning, religion, and Zionism; the trick is to learn the side or facet of the diamond that is most meaningful to you."

This year we were also fortunate to have our very own "Scholar in Residence", **Rabbi Katz**, present his program, *"Poetry and Catastrophe: Jewish Literary Responses to Tragedy."* I have to admit that I wasn't too keen on attending when I found out the topic was about catastrophe and poetry. I kind of felt it would be another depressing lecture about Jewish catastrophe (after attending the Holocaust memorial service) I could live without. Yet, it didn't turn out that way.

Rabbi Katz began his lecture by discussing 9/11 and the literary responses to that event- poems and songs that reproduced the horror and vividness of the event, the visceral angry responses, and the subsequent calls for action and retaliation. He then stepped back from our present day American catastrophe and the literary responses to that event to present the historical background of the Kishinev Pogrom in Russia and the literary responses of that time. In the early 1900's, the Czar started to blame the Jews for the revolutionary movement that was starting to take place and staged this pogrom during Easter/Passover, 1903. During the pogrom, 49 people were killed in one day- more people than were killed in all of the pogroms in the 1880's- homes were destroyed and over 2,000 people were made homeless.

Our Rabbi went on to compare and contrast several literary responses to this catastrophic event. The responses took the form of eyewitness accounts, songs, poems, long tomes, and religious prayer. The reactions and sentiments differed over the course of time. The first published poetic response/song, "Have Pity" written by Simon Frug, reflected the sentiment that it was the destiny of Jews to suffer and that it was just a matter of when and where the next tragedy will happen and there is nothing that can be done. Such is our lot in life and the only response that is called for is showing mercy for the dead. The same somber attitude was also portrayed by the poem, "Daniel in the Lion's Den", by David Frischman, which reflected the lack of humanity in all humans. The Rabbi then went on to contrast these responses to two other literary works, "Sharpen, Flint of Mine" by Yakov Cahan, and "In the City of Slaughter" by Chaim Nachman. In "Sharpen, Flint of Mine," God tells the people not to be passive but to be aggressive, and go out and defend themselves. "In the City of Slaughter" God takes the author, Bialik, on a tour of the places in the city where the event happened. He portrays the Jews as being weak, hiding while their wives were getting raped etc., and describes God's being disgusted with their passivity and cowardliness.

This tome shamed the Jews into realizing that they can never let this happen again and thereby changed the course of Jewish history. When a young man named Yitzhak Shimshelevich read Nachman's poem, he was inspired to create Jewish self - defense groups to prevent pogroms like Kishinev from happening. Later on, he went to Israel and found the Arabs were attacking Jewish settlements. He then formed a group to take direct action against the Arabs. Ultimately, this led to the beginning of a bigger Jewish defense group, which transformed itself into the Haganah in 1920. So, there is a direct link between this poem, the concept of Jewish self-defense, the formation of the Haganah, and ultimately the formation of the State of Israel! The final outcome of this story was that Yitzhak Shimshelevich eventually changed his name to Yitzhak Ben-Zvi- who was the second president of the State of Israel!

As a summation to the lecture, Rabbi Katz weaved a timeline between the songs, poems, and accounts that were written and how they had an impact - by relating emotional reactions to past historical events, and also acting as an impetus to create future history. He stated, "Sometimes, not always, the right poem expresses the right things that can change the course of history."

Not so depressing after all…in fact, quite uplifting!

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